

Upon This Rock (Core Values) (4)

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After a one week break from our series of Core Values here at Cedar Grove, we come to the fourth one.

Just to quickly remind us this morning...

Vision:

Cedar Grove Baptist Church exists to create a space where people and families can *meet* Jesus, *find* community, and *grow* in their faith.

Mission:

Our purpose is to *love* others unconditionally, *learn* about God increasingly, *live* to share Jesus intentionally and *lead* others to Christ continually in Lebanon, TN and throughout the whole world.

Neither of these statements will matter. however, if we do not value the right things in the right way.

What you value in life is what will direct your life.

The way you make decisions is directly connected to what you deem important or not important.

We are looking at these core values in the form of statements of agreement for each one.

The first one...

I will uphold the sanctity of the family

Our families can either be something that brings us closer to God or further from God. God did not bless us with a family to set them up as idols in our life. Rather, He desires

the family to be a place of holiness and faith building.

I will live daily with integrity in thought, word, and deed.

To live honestly before God and others is the only way to back up a beautiful testimony of the change God has made in your life.

I will build and grow each of the four relationships represented in the purpose statement of my church.

Our mission statements speaks of three main relationships we all have whether stewarded well or not...

Our relationship with others. Our relationship with God and His Word. Our relationship with the mission.

This morning we continue right along with our fourth core value...

Commitment

Without commitment it is difficult to have a thriving ministry of any kind.

Our statement of agreement is:

I will wholeheartedly commit myself to the purpose and mission of my church.

Pray.

If there is anything missing from the church today it is this...people being committed to the purpose and mission.

There is a stat that I cannot stand hearing but when looked at closely it is sadly accurate.

10% of the people in a local church do 90% of the work.

Now, with that being said, I do want to encourage you today. I do believe that we are seeing a shift in the culture at Cedar Grove.

Although there is more help needed, we do have a good group of people that desire to help and see the ministry and Gospel impact grow.

We ought not take this for granted. That being said, there are many who are still on the sidelines. There are many who are content with letting someone else do it. There are many who do not have any commitment to the purpose and mission of this church.

Coming on Sunday is simply not enough. Coming to the big events is simply not enough. Those are results of the commitment of others who work hard to make sure we have a ministry of excellence here.

These people who are content on the sidelines are what I would call on the fringe.

If you are uncomfortable right now and feel like I am speaking to you I need you to hear me with all the love in my heart...I am speaking to you.

The whole point of this core value is to get you from the fringe to the fold.

There is three ways for this to happen. Three ways that we show our commitment to the purpose and mission of this church.

First,

By attending faithfully.

How do you value the corporate gathering of believers?

God makes it clear that it should be a priority.

Hebrews 10:25 KJV 1900

²⁵ Not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as the manner of some *is*; but exhorting *one another*: and so much the more, as ye see the day approaching.

That word “manner” means

Dictionary of Biblical Languages with Semantic Domains: Greek (New Testament) 1621 ἔθος

ἔθος (ethos), custom, practice, habit

You know what breaks my heart? When people do not understand how important the family of God is.

I hear people all the time say things like this...

“Well, it’s travel ball season, we will make it when we can!”

“It’s hunting season, I will be in the woods with God most of the next several months!”

“We just got a lot going on right now...”

“We got family coming in...”

“Preacher, this never happens but I overslept...”

Now, I want us to understand something this morning. Do not hear what I am not saying. It is not a sin to miss church every now and again. Things do happen. Sports, other activities, hunting family time are all okay...IN THEIR PROPER PLACE.

These things become a problem when they become create a habit of neglecting the gathering of the saints.

This goes beyond Sunday morning. You do realize that we have lifegroups on Sunday morning at 9:15? “That is just too early for us to make it. It is difficult to get everyone ready and on time...

Than prioritize it better in your home. Remember the commitment we are making...to the purpose and mission of the church. One of those commitments is to learn about God increasingly. Lifegroups provides a space where we can both grow in the faith and in relationship with each other!

“Well I am not a fan of how they teach...” Then get up and teach a group yourself. May give you a greater appreciation of the work that is put in.

How do we go from a lack of commitment to faithfully attending church?

We understand why we are here...

Look at the build up of our scripture here in Hebrews 10

Hebrews 10:23-25 KJV 1900

²³ Let us hold fast the profession of *our* faith without wavering; (for he *is* faithful that promised;) ²⁴ And let us consider one another to provoke unto love and to good works:

²⁵ Not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as the manner of some *is*; but exhorting *one another*: and so much the more, as ye see the day approaching.

When you look at church attendance in the reality that your presence encourages, uplifts, and provokes others to keep doing good...that's when everything changes. Our faithful attendance is a result of considering each other.

And in doing so we glorify God together!

But our faithful attendance is only one part.

I will wholeheartedly commit myself to the purpose and mission of my church.

By giving cheerfully.

This is one of the most overly debated and controversial practices in the church today. Should I give? How much do I give? Why do we even give? Is the tithe biblical?

First off, it is important to understand that the principle of the tithe predates the law.

Both Abraham and Jacob hundreds of years before the Mosaic law was given decided to give a tenth of their possessions to the Lord.

So, it's not that it is mandated to the NT church to give a percentage, however, not giving is not an option. Also, a tithe is a good way to prioritize God first in your life.

In the culture we live in, where our money goes, there is our heart.

As a matter of fact, this is a truth that has been around for a long time.

In the sermon on the mount Jesus says this in Matthew 6:21

Matthew 6:21 KJV 1900

²¹ For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also.

So where do we give?

If we follow the practice in the OT we see we are to give to the storehouse.

Malachi 3:10 NASB95

¹⁰ “Bring the whole tithe into the storehouse, so that there may be food in My house, and test Me now in this,” says the LORD of hosts, “if I will not open for you the windows of heaven and pour out for you a blessing until it overflows.

A giving church is a thriving church. We must understand this...

When we give generously and intentionally we lift the burden of financial limitations on magnifying the ministry of this local church.

In doing so we lift up the name of Jesus!

Your tithe goes to the church. “Well I don’t like how they spend the money where I go...”

Two options here...

A. Change your heart posture from pride to humility.

B. Leave that church and go somewhere you feel comfortable giving.

Giving to external ministries is fine, but it’s not giving to the storehouse. If your outside giving to charities or other ministries replaces your giving to the local church you are hindering the ministry you are supposed to be committed to.

Is this just an OT principle? No.

Acts 4:34–37 KJV 1900

³⁴ Neither was there any among them that lacked: for as many as were possessors of lands or houses sold them, and brought the prices of the things that were sold, ³⁵ And laid *them* down at the apostles’ feet: and distribution was made unto every man

according as he had need.

³⁶ And Joses, who by the apostles was surnamed Barnabas, (which is, being interpreted, The son of consolation,) a Levite, *and* of the country of Cyprus, ³⁷ Having land, sold *it*, and brought the money, and laid *it* at the apostles' feet.

This is not a call to sell your possessions and lay it at the doorstep of the church, this is a call to give faithfully to the ministry effort that you are committed to.

And we do so cheerfully.

2 Corinthians 9:7 NASB95

⁷ Each one *must do* just as he has purposed in his heart, not grudgingly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver.

This is not allowing for someone not to give, rather Paul is revealing how we ought to give compared to how we ought not to give.

Are you happy to give to this church in order to see the name of Jesus spread more in our community?

If not...why not?

I want to share a sobering reality here at Cedar Grove...

There are no names on my part attached to these numbers. As the pastor i cannot allow any temptation to care about someone more than another based on giving.

The last 6 months we average 16-18 givers a week. This is considering all modes of giving on an average.

Our average Sunday attendance during this time has been between 150-165.

Church, how much are we hindering the progress of this church by our lack of cheerful and faithful giving?

“Well, God doesn’t need money to get things done...” You don’t think that way about anything else in your life. Stop hiding behind false spiritualism.

Now, I do want to encourage... On May 17th we had our Vision Sunday. This yearly Vision Offering is what paid for the chairs you are sitting in and the tables you sat at to eat on Sunday.

On that Sunday we had 35 givers give. That is not including online or cash. We totaled over \$21,000. That is over 4 times the amount of our current weekly need.

And you know what was beautiful about that giving? There was an evident anticipation and excitement of what God was going to do.

No where in scripture will you find a giving amount required, just a giving heart required.

I will wholeheartedly commit myself to the purpose and mission of my church.

By working diligently.

You realize anything worth having requires hard work and discipline.

King Solomon, the wisest and richest person in history wrote this about hard work...

Proverbs 13:4 NKJV

⁴ The soul of a lazy *man* desires, and *has* nothing; But the soul of the diligent shall be made rich.

God forbid we work hard everywhere else in our life except the house of God.

God forbid laziness be an issue here at Cedar Grove.

I don't want us to miss what Solomon is saying here...people take this Proverbs and connect it only to getting rich in money or material things.

Look at the verse again...

Proverbs 13:4 NKJV

⁴ The **soul** of a lazy *man* desires, and *has* nothing; But the **soul** of the diligent shall be made rich.

That word “soul” means...

Enhanced Brown-Driver-Briggs Hebrew and English Lexicon נַפֶּשׁ

soul, living being, life, self, person, desire, appetite, emotion, and passion

To put this simply the “soul” encompasses the whole person—physical, moral, and spiritual dimensions. Not just material circumstances.

Our labor, our work for the Lord is never in vain.

1 Corinthians 15:58 NKJV

⁵⁸ Therefore, my beloved brethren, be steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, knowing that your labor is not in vain in the Lord.

Do you want more people to come to know Jesus through your effort and work?

Proverbs 16:3 NASB95

³ Commit your works to the LORD And your plans will be established.

When we are committed to the purpose and mission of the church...

We will attend faithfully, give cheerfully, and work diligently.

The result? God working through us to accomplish His will.